

Q Are there any sexual positions that might help us conceive?

No, there is no scientific evidence that having sex in a particular position increases your chances of conception. There are unsupported claims that it helps to have sex in the missionary position so that the man is on top, or in positions that allow deep penetration, and that a female orgasm can help to pull sperm farther into the cervix. You don't need to lie on your back with your legs raised after sex to give the sperm the best chance of success either! However, it certainly doesn't hurt to give any of these methods a try—just having sex, in whatever position you like, will improve your chances of getting pregnant.

Q I've got two sons. How can I improve my chances of conceiving a girl?

It would be nice to think that you can influence the gender of your baby, but unfortunately there is no evidence that you can. Whether your baby is a boy or a girl is dependent on whether the sperm that fertilizes the egg carries an X chromosome (for a girl) or a Y chromosome (for a boy), and this is purely a matter of chance.

Nevertheless, you are not the first to ask this question and there are lots of old wives' tales about it! In the 1960s, a theory called the Shettles Method claimed that X-bearing sperm survive longer in the cervix but move more slowly than faster, smaller, though less healthy, Y-bearing sperm. With this in mind, the theory suggested that you should have sex as close to ovulation as possible for a boy, but two to three days before ovulation for a girl. There are some sex-selection kits available online that utilize this theory, but this method has not been scientifically proven.

Another theory for natural sex selection, also not scientifically proven, is the Whelan Method. This advises having sex two to three days before ovulation for a girl and four to five days before the basal body temperature rises to conceive a boy—which is the opposite advice to the Shettles Method. The Whelan Method also advocates eating a diet that is high in calcium and magnesium for a boy, and eating lots of salty and potassium-rich foods for a girl.

Q How long will it take for us to get pregnant?

The time it takes will depend on many different factors, but be aware that it is normal for even a fertile couple to take a year, or even two, to conceive.

Figures reveal that on average more than 80 percent of couples under the age of 40 get pregnant within a year if they have regular unprotected sex; more than 90 percent achieve pregnancy in two years. Naturally, it is frustrating if conception is taking a long time for you, but the figures show that it is worthwhile to keep going.

Whatever your age, you can both make dietary and lifestyle changes to improve your chances of conceiving (see pp.50–51). You can also monitor when you ovulate to increase your chances of success (see opposite).

However, some experts argue that staying relaxed and not focusing too much on tracking ovulation will help you to conceive.

If you have been having unprotected sex for a year without success, consider seeing your doctor about your fertility health.

If you are a woman over 35 and you haven't conceived after six months of regular unprotected sex, seek medical advice at this point (statistically, fertility rates drop at age 35). You should also seek advice if you have irregular periods or are worried about your fallopian tubes due to your medical history.

Make sure you are having sex on a regular basis. Some couples simply don't have sex often enough to get pregnant!

AVERAGE CONCEPTION RATES IN FERTILE COUPLES

After a year of trying, 93 out of 100 couples in a US study achieved a pregnancy, at the rates set out below.

MONTH	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10	11	12
PERCENTAGE OF COUPLES PREGNANT	20	36	49	59	67	74	79	83	86	89	91	93

Q We have one child and know we want another. How long should we wait before trying to get pregnant?

This may depend on your experience the first time around. If you had a normal pregnancy with no complications, there is no reason not to conceive again once you feel ready. However, consider factors such as whether you have the energy to care for a young baby while pregnant and whether you want some time to enjoy the child that you have.

If it took a while for you to conceive, you may want to start trying to get pregnant as soon as you feel ready, though be prepared that you could conceive more quickly this time around. Conversely, if you conceived very

quickly last time, it is not unusual for it to take longer to get pregnant again.

If you had a cesarean section with your first baby, wait for at least a year before getting pregnant again. This is to give your body enough time to recover—becoming pregnant sooner can double the risk of complications in the next pregnancy. Waiting a year also gives your incision a chance to heal. If you would like a vaginal birth next time and you're not completely healed, there is more chance of rupture during a VBAC (vaginal birth after cesarean section).

Any medical complications experienced in your first pregnancy, such as severe vomiting (hyperemesis gravidarum), preeclampsia, gestational diabetes, or a premature birth, could reoccur. You may want to discuss the likelihood of this with your doctor before you begin trying to get pregnant again.